The morning air was sharp, tinged with the scent of metal and dust from the fort. Robert and the other recruits moved in formation, boots crunching over gravel paths, rifles slung carefully at their sides. The uniform was crisp, functional, nothing ornamental, gray tunic, reinforced vest, heavy boots. Even though it was basic, Robert couldn't help but notice how much discipline the clothing implied. This wasn't pretend. This was real.

Steve stood on the drill ground, arms crossed, watching with a critical eye. "Remember," he barked, "precision saves lives. Pay attention. Do not be the weak link."

Sarah was nearby, clipboard in hand, noting names and performance, quietly correcting postures, offering a nod or a word of encouragement to the younger recruits. She wasn't drilling them, she was observing, learning who would rise to responsibility and who would falter under pressure.

Robert slipped into the rhythm easily. Years of careful observation, of building, repairing, measuring, and calculating, now applied to human coordination. Drill steps became like clockwork, movements efficient. The other recruits were a mix, some naturally adept, some clumsy, some aggressive, all learning. Robert fit somewhere near the top of the pack without trying.

Days and weeks passed in a blur. Weapons familiarization, guard rotations, emergency drills. Early mornings and late nights. The monotony of marching, the small victories of mastering a complicated mechanism, the weight of a loaded rifle, all of it built muscle memory and self-confidence. Every mistake was noticed, corrected, and cataloged. Every success carried a quiet, undeniable satisfaction.

Meals were quick, utilitarian, and shared under strict time constraints. Robert found himself beside familiar faces: Kevin, steady and dependable; a few of the older teens and young adults who had also earned early spots on the ship; and occasionally Laura, on her own path, suited in medical colors rather than combat gray. Their eyes would meet across the mess tables, a brief exchange, a flicker of warmth before the orders pulled them apart.

During free moments, Robert cleaned his rifle, checking springs and weights, making minor adjustments to improve balance. It wasn't play, it was learning responsibility, taking ownership of equipment that might one day save lives. Drill instructors noted his diligence, occasionally letting him assist in teaching younger recruits. He didn't boast. He just did the work.

Evenings brought inspection and debrief. Exhaustion hung heavy, but Robert felt alive in a way he hadn't before. Every day carved a little more discipline, a little more confidence, a little more awareness of the world and his place in it. The militia wasn't glamorous. It wasn't a game. It was preparation, anticipation, and the cultivation of trust, both in himself and in the people around him.

And always, in the back of his mind, was Laura. The thought of her, focused, determined, already learning how to save lives in her own way, reminded him of the stakes. This wasn't just about training for survival. It was about the world they hoped to inhabit together. The discipline, the drills, the long hours, it all had a purpose beyond order. It was a foundation for what they both would carry forward.

By the end of the training period, Robert's movements were automatic, his reflexes sharper, and his confidence steadier. The drills once awkward or exhausting at first were now routine, and his eyes constantly scanned the surroundings, noting every detail, every potential threat.

The militia had begun. And with it, Robert's final steps into adulthood.

The fort hummed with quiet efficiency. Robert moved between his workshop and the militia posts with a rhythm he had learned over the past years. His hands, calloused from building walls, repairing pumps, and lifting heavy beams, now handled delicate tools with the same precision, tightening a screw, adjusting a spring, aligning the chamber of a pellet rifle that still wasn't quite finished. Three full-time employees worked alongside him, older men and women who had seen too many battles and too many mistakes, yet respected the precision and focus of the young man now directing their work.

Laura, in contrast, moved through her own apprenticeship with calm determination. The local medical post was busy, understaffed, and she was learning fast. Bandages, injections, reading vitals, stabilizing patients, every shift pushed her further, molding her into the kind of nurse they would need on the ships. They rarely saw each other during the day, but when they did, it was in brief, meaningful glances, or small smiles across a crowded workshop or hospital ward. No words were needed.

Robert stepped back from the partially assembled rifle, wiping sweat from his brow. He glanced up at the sky. Lethe had changed. What had once been a bright, distant star now hung in the sky like a tiny silvery red moon, delicate but unmistakably real. The sight carried a weight he hadn't expected, small, quiet, and strangely comforting.

The fifth ship was underway. Only a thousand people could be accommodated so far, half of the population they were trying to save. Younger recruits filled the seats first, leaving the older, wiser hands behind. They had the choice to go, but most refused until the young had a place. Instead, they offered their experience, their labor, their time. They trained, taught, repaired, and built, refusing the promise of escape in favor of preparing others.

Robert felt the tension in the air, not panic, not fear, but the quiet, persistent pressure of responsibility. Every nail he hammered, every blueprint he marked, carried more weight than it had before. Mistakes could mean lives lost, delays could cost the ships, and yet the world continued, moving forward in its messy, stubborn way.

At the end of a long day, he stepped outside, brushing sawdust from his hands, and looked toward the rising moonlight reflecting off the steel framework of the fifth ship. Laura had finished her shift at the medical post and was already walking along the path to meet him. She carried a satchel of tools for minor repairs, tucked neatly at her side. They walked together in companionable silence, shoulders brushing occasionally, the quiet comfort of presence outweighing the need for conversation.

"So, Mark said you've almost finished the rifle," Laura said softly, nudging him with her elbow.

"Almost," he said. "If I could ever find the time." He glanced at her, and there was no frustration, just a shared understanding of their burdens. They were both building something larger than themselves.

The sky deepened, Lethe shimmering like a small promise of darkness to come. Robert felt it again, the mixture of calm acceptance and the underlying tension that had become a constant companion. Life was uncertain, dangerous, and unfinished, but in the quiet alignment of purpose, work, and shared presence, it was bearable. It was enough.

Together, they watched the dark star, knowing the world they had built, the people they were protecting, and the fragile thread of hope they were weaving would carry them forward. And though separation and duty awaited, it was no longer a thing to fear, only a thing to meet with steady hands and clear hearts.

The late afternoon sunlight slanted through the workshop windows, catching dust motes and glinting off the new OmniSlate Robert had been sketching on. The old OmniSlate, as sturdy as the devices were, had finally given up the ghost and even Sarah couldn't resurrect it this time. Plates of roasted vegetables, fresh steaks, and golden potatoes sat on the table, steam curling in lazy ribbons. Nina had curled herself into a tight ball on the windowsill, keeping an eye on the table but not daring to interfere.

Laura slid into the seat across from him, brushing a stray strand of hair behind her ear. "You're still fiddling with that thing?" she asked, nodding toward the OmniSlate.

Robert grinned, tapping at the schematics of the high-powered pellet rifle. "Just trying to finalize the chamber, if I get this right, it'll actually outshoot a black powder gun."

Laura reached across the table and smacked his hand. "Put it away for a few hours! Silly men are always playing with their toys."

He raised his hands in mock surrender, the corners of his mouth tugging into a shy smile. "Alright, alright… no more tinkering."

They ate slowly, stealing bites between conversation, comfortable silences, and occasional laughter. Laura told him about the nurse shortage at Ravenholt and how she had to leave tonight to cover the shifts. Robert nodded, pretending to focus on his steak, though his eyes followed her every movement.

"Sunday?" he asked finally, voice low.

Laura gave him a small smile, brushing her fingers along the edge of her plate. "Sunday. If we're lucky."

"No way to get out of that I suppose. We'll make sure to bring you some extra fish when we get back from bear lake. We should be back on Saturday, but there will be more chances before launch next year. Really won't be the same without you there."

They talked quietly about small things, the weather, the farm, which of their friends would need the most help over the next week, anything to stretch the hours. Every glance, every laugh, every shared bite carried a kind of intimacy that didn't need words. It was easy, soft, and fragile in a way that made it feel precious.

Finally, the meal ended. Plates cleared, Nina pawed gently at Laura's ankle, demanding attention. Robert slid his chair back. "I'll walk you out," he said, taking her hand briefly.

At the door, Laura turned to him, tilting her head with a teasing smile. "You know, I want to get married on Earth before it's gone."

Robert chuckled, brushing a strand of her hair back. "I want to get married while we're blasting off, first couple of escapees to tie the knot in orbit."

Laura laughed, the sound bright and clear. "No way we're waiting another whole year. Keep it up, buddy, and we'll be married Sunday if I have to drag my parents and the pastor over here myself. Don't tease me about such things!"

Robert just smiled, tugging her close for a quick, careful kiss. Soft, warm, and full of promise.

They pulled apart, lingering for a moment, hands still brushing. "Go save some lives," he said quietly.

"Enjoy your fishing and you, keep everyone from burning down the fort while I'm gone," she teased, stepping into the late afternoon light.

Robert watched her go, heart lighter despite the tension of duties ahead. The world was still chaotic, still uncertain, still full of work and responsibility, but for this moment, for this shared laugh, this quiet connection, it was enough.

Nina meowed, hopping onto his shoulder as if to remind him he had a life of his own to tend to. Robert grinned at her, then turned back toward the workshop, ready to meet the night shift, already counting the hours until Sunday.